f813d8fb-e77d-4f1a-a208-7335e219a8b4

<current>

<request>

You are working on an issue in the 'dotnet/Nerdbank.GitVersioning' repository.

<repository_context>
I've cloned the repository in the directory /home/runner/work/Nerdbank.GitVersioning/Nerdbank.GitVersioning (not in /tmp/inputs). Always use absolute paths when referring to files in the repository.
</repository_context>

<current_datetime>2025-12-08T14:43:36.274Z</current_datetime>

Consider the following problem statement:

<problem_statement>

This section details on the original issue you should resolve

<issue_title>Feature: Allow inheriting version.json to add unstable/prerelease suffix without duplicating version number</issue_title>
<issue_description>## Feature request: Inherit version number but allow unstable suffix in version.json

Currently, when using version.json inheritance in Nerdbank.GitVersioning, to publish an "unstable" prerelease from a stable branch (such as when one particular package is still considered unstable while its peers are already stable), the inherited version number must be hard-coded into both the original and the inheriting version.json. This can easily get out of sync and is error-prone.

Proposed feature:

Allow a version.json file to inherit the base version from an ancestor but append or override the 'prerelease' (unstable) portion without hard-coding the inherited version number. For example:

```json
{
  "$schema": "https://raw.githubusercontent.com/dotnet/Nerdbank.GitVersioning/master/version.schema.json",
  "inherit": true,
  "prerelease": "beta"
}
```

or some similar property that enables the inheriting version.json to add/change only the prerelease suffix while continuing to inherit the numerics.

Motivation / scenario:
- Facilitate clean handling of release branches and dev branches without synchronized version updates in multiple files.
- Reduce maintenance friction and mistakes in version management workflows.

Desired outcome:
- A way to specify only a prerelease suffix in version.json that augments (does not override) an inherited version, without repeating or hardcoding the version numbers.
- The new `prerelease` property should be allowable only on version.json files that inherit, and which do _not_ specify any prerelease suffix within their `version` property.
- Setting `"prerelease": ""` explicitly should have the effect of _suppressing_ a prerelease suffix that might have been otherwise inherited. But merely omitting the `prerelease` property will have the effect of relying wholly on the `version` property (if specified) or inheriting whatever the parent `version.json` file specifies.
- New tests
- Updated documentation
- Updated version.schema.json. The schema should be written such that `prerelease` is only allowed when `inherit: true` is specified. Ideally it also forbids `-` appearing in the `version` property at the same time as the `prerelease` property appears, but only if that doesn't require cloning a huge chunk of schema which will be a maintenance burden.

</issue_description>

Comments on the Issue (you are @copilot in this section)

<comments>
</comments>

</problem_statement>

Implement the necessary changes to the repository so that the requirements specified in the <problem_statement> are met.

A **CI/Build Failure** has been mentioned in the problem statement, make sure to follow your instructions for addressing CI/Build Failures.